at the outlets in the bagasse pit to keep the flow, but he wasn't doing enough. Bored as I was, I asked him to get out and took his place in the pit. Getting a feel of what the lowest grade worker does gives you an idea of wholesomeness. It works in a bagasse pit; it works in a rocket assembly clean room.

So, here I was, sweating it out in the bagasse pit, when I felt someone towering over me. It was the general manager, a genial Scot who loved to pay surprise visits to the work floor after a couple of sun-downers. He did not utter a word, though he was surprised that an engineer was doing the job of a menial worker. I was to be surprised soon with a letter cutting short my three-year training period to six months.

Parthasarathy, a diploma holder and my immediate boss with an innate sense of ridicule for youngsters with an engineering degree and not experience, was not impressed when I gave him the news of my promotion. Curiously enough, my immediate boss appeared to be in the dark about it.

'Six months?' he said. 'You mean they are reducing your training period by six months?' I explained, 'No, the total training period would now be only six months.'

'So you think now you know the entire operations of the factory?'

That was the truth, but I did not reply.

He tried his best to make life difficult for me, but with little success, as the general manager liked me. Call it my luck, the super bosses having a soft corner for me continued when I was with ISRO, where I always had the ears of Vikram Sarabhai, Satish Dhawan and U R Rao, the three greatest chairmen of ISRO.

The promotion as assistant engineer of the sugar factory came with loads of money—Rs 500 a month—and some other perks like a membership in the officer's club which was open only to officer-grade employees and their families. My entry did not go well with some club members who were not amused by my 'out of turn' promotion, but soon many of them turned to be my friends, thanks to my skills in the games of bridge and billiards. Parthasarathy, my prime adversary at work became my favourite partner at the bridge table. The reason was simple: There was just